



# TARGET-90

**JKBOSE CLASS-11<sup>TH</sup>**

**(HORNBILL BOOK)**

**Prose Section**

One shot

**ENGLISH**

**Hussain Sir**



# Topics To Be Covered

- 1 THE PORTRAIT OF A LADY**
- 2 “WE’RE NOT AFRAID TO DIE... IF WE CAN ALL BE TOGETHER”**
- 3 DISCOVERING TUT: THE SAGA CONTINUES**
- 4 THE AILING PLANET: THE GREEN MOVEMENT’S ROLE**
- 5 THE ADVENTURE**
- 6 SILK ROAD**

# 1 THE PORTRAIT OF A LADY



# 2 "WE'RE NOT AFRAID TO DIE... IF WE CAN ALL BE TOGETHER"



# 3 DISCOVERING TUT: THE SAGA CONTINUES



# 4 THE AILING PLANET

## THE GREEN MOVEMENT'S ROLE



# 5 THE ADVENTURE



# 6 SILK ROAD



# **PROSE – 1**

## **The Portrait of a Lady**

# **The Portrait of a Lady**

## **By~ Khushwant Singh**



### **INTRODUCTION**

The story is a touching account of the writer's relationship with his grandmother. It highlights the bond of love, respect, and affection between the author and his grandmother, and shows how life, relationships, and traditions change with time. The narrative is written in first person, giving it a personal and emotional touch.

# The Portrait of a Lady

## By~ Khushwant Singh



### CHAPTER SUMMARY

In 'The Portrait of a Lady', *Khushwant Singh* has given an account of his grandmother. He draws a life-like portrait. She was very old. Her face was wrinkled.

Her hair was white. It was hard to believe that once she had been young and pretty.

His grandfather's picture hung above the mantelpiece in the drawing room. He wore a big turban. His clothes were loose. He looked at least a hundred years old. It was hard to believe that he had once a wife or children.

# **The Portrait of a Lady**

## **By~ Khushwant Singh**



Khushwant Singh's grandmother was a short lady. She was fat and slightly bent. She couldn't walk straight. She hobbled about the house. She had to keep one hand on her waist. It was to balance her stoop. In the other she held a rosary. She was always telling the beads. Her lips constantly moved in prayer. She put on white clothes. Her silver locks scattered over her pale face. She looked like snowy mountains in winter. She was a picture of peace and contentment. She was very old. Perhaps she could not have looked older. She looked the same for the last twenty years.

# **The Portrait of a Lady**

## **By~ Khushwant Singh**



Khushwant Singh and his grandmother were good friends. His parents went to the city. They left him with her in the village. She took good care of him. She used to wake him up in the morning. She got him ready for school. She said her morning prayer in a sing-song manner. She hoped that he would learn it by heart. He liked her voice but never bothered to learn it. Then she would fetch his wooden slate.

She had already washed it and plastered it with yellow chalk. She would take an earthen inkpot and a red-pen. She would tie them in a bundle and hand it to him. She would give him a thick stale chapatti with little butter and sugar spread on it. It was his breakfast. She carried several stale chapattis with her for the village dogs.

# **The Portrait of a Lady**

## **By~ Khushwant Singh**



His grandmother always went to school with him. The school was attached to the temple. The priest taught children the alphabet and the morning prayer. The children sat in two rows in the verandah. They would sing the alphabet or the prayer in a chorus. The grandmother sat inside the temple. She would read holy books. Then they would walk home together. The village dogs would gather at the temple door.

They threw chapattis to them. The dogs would growl and fight with each other.

The narrator's parents sent for them in the city. It was a turning point in their friendship. They shared the same room. But the grandmother no longer went to school with him. The narrator used to go to an English school in a motor bus. There were no dogs in the streets. So the grandmother took to feeding the sparrows.

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Years rolled by. They saw less of each other. Sometimes she would ask him what the teacher had taught him. She did not believe in the things they taught at the English school. She was unhappy. She did not like English or Science. She felt sad that there was no teaching about God and the scriptures at school. The narrator one day told her that they were being given music lessons. She was disturbed. She thought music quite indecent. For her, it was good only for prostitutes and beggars. It was not meant for gentle folk.

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## **By~ Khushwant Singh**



The narrator went to university. He was given a room of his own. The common link of friendship was broken. The grandmother accepted her loneliness quietly. She was always busy with her spinning wheel and reciting prayers. She rarely talked to anyone. In the afternoon, she relaxed for a while. Then she would feed the sparrows. She sat in the verandah. She broke the bread into little bits. Then she would throw them to sparrows. Hundreds of sparrows came there. They created a hell of noise. Some came and sat on her legs. Others would sit on her shoulders. Some would sit even on her head. She smiled but never frightened them away. Feeding the sparrows was the happiest half-hour of the day for her.

# **The Portrait of a Lady**

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The narrator decided to go abroad for higher studies. He was to remain away for five years. The grandmother was very old. She could die any moment. The narrator was worried. But the grandmother was not upset. She showed no emotion. She came to the railway station to see him off. Her lips moved in prayer. Her mind was lost in prayer. Her fingers were busy telling the beads of her rosary. She kissed his forehead silently. The narrator thought that it was the last sign of physical contact between them.

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The narrator returned home after five years. His grandmother met him at the station. She did not look a day older. She did not speak anything. She held him in her arms. She went on reciting her prayers. In the afternoon she fed the sparrows as usual. In the evening a change came over her. She didn't pray. She collected the women of the neighborhood. She got an old drum. She continued thumping the old drum for several hours. She started singing. She sang of the homecoming of warriors. They had to persuade her to stop. She might overstrain herself. It was for the first time that she had forgotten to pray.

# **The Portrait of a Lady**

## **By~ Khushwant Singh**



The next morning she fell ill. She had a mild fever. She told them that her end was near. She realised that she had forgotten to pray. She didn't want to talk. It would be a waste of time. She ignored their requests. She lay peacefully in bed. She was praying and telling beads. Then her lips stopped moving. The rosary fell down from her lifeless fingers. Her face looked pale but peaceful. She was dead. She was laid on the ground. She was covered with a red shawl. Arrangements for her funeral were being made.

# **The Portrait of a Lady**

## **By~ Khushwant Singh**



It was evening. The sun was setting. They brought a wooden stretcher. They stopped halfway in the courtyard. Thousands of sparrows sat near her dead body. They did not chirrup. Everyone felt sorry for the birds. The narrator's mother brought some bread. She broke it into little crumbs. She threw these crumbs to the sparrows. The birds took no notice of them. Then they carried her dead body outside. The sparrows flew away quietly. The crumbs of bread still remained lying there in the courtyard. Evidently, the sparrows had come to mourn the death of the grandmother.

## **PROSE – 2**

**“WE’RE NOT AFRAID TO DIE...  
IF WE CAN ALL BE TOGETHER”**

# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **The Dream of Sailing**

In July 1976, Gordon Cook, his wife Mary, and their two children Jonathan, aged six, and Suzanne, aged seven, set out from Plymouth, England, to duplicate Captain James Cook's famous voyage around the world that had taken place two hundred years earlier. The couple had been preparing for this adventure for sixteen years. They had practiced sailing in the rough waters of Britain, studied navigation, and saved money to build a strong boat. Their boat, named Wavewalker, was professionally built. It was twenty-three metres long, weighed thirty tons, and was designed to withstand rough seas. Their children were excited about the journey, and the family's spirits were high as they began their adventure.



# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **The Journey to Cape Town**

The first part of the journey went smoothly. The family sailed down the west coast of Africa and reached the Cape of Good Hope. From there, they sailed to Cape Town, South Africa. Everything went according to plan, and they felt confident about the voyage. But they knew the most dangerous part still lay ahead—the southern Indian Ocean, which was notorious for its violent weather and huge waves.

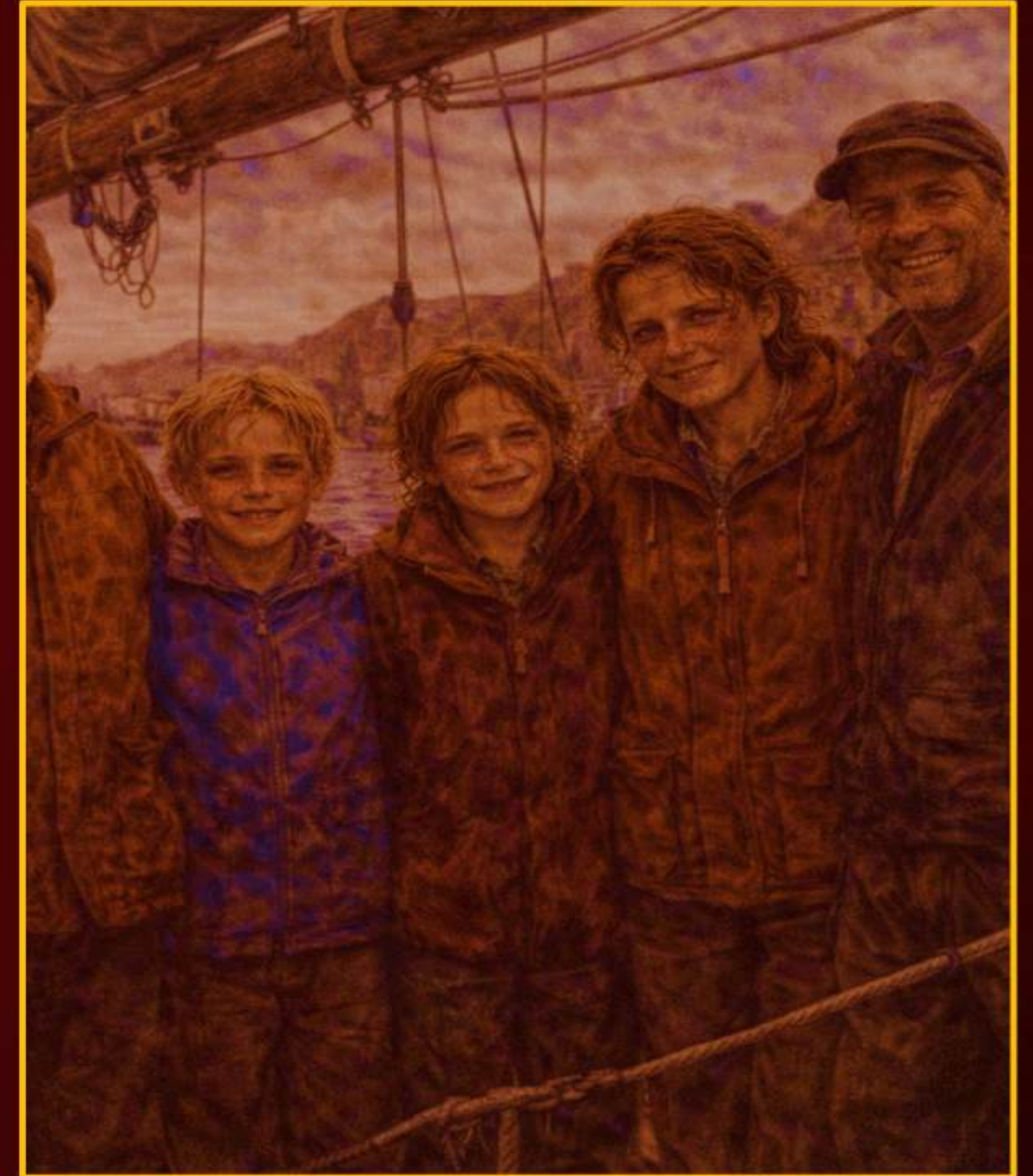


# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **Hiring Extra Crew**

To prepare for this rough stretch, Gordon hired two experienced crewmen to help them: Larry Vigil, an American, and Herb Seigler, a Swiss. Both were expert sailors who could handle emergency situations. With their help, the family was ready to face the longest and most dangerous leg of their 105,000-kilometre journey.



# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **Christmas at Sea**

By December 25, 1976, they were about 3,500 kilometres east of Cape Town. The family celebrated Christmas at sea. Although the weather was turning bad and the waves were growing stronger, their spirits remained cheerful. They did not know that greater trouble was just around the corner.

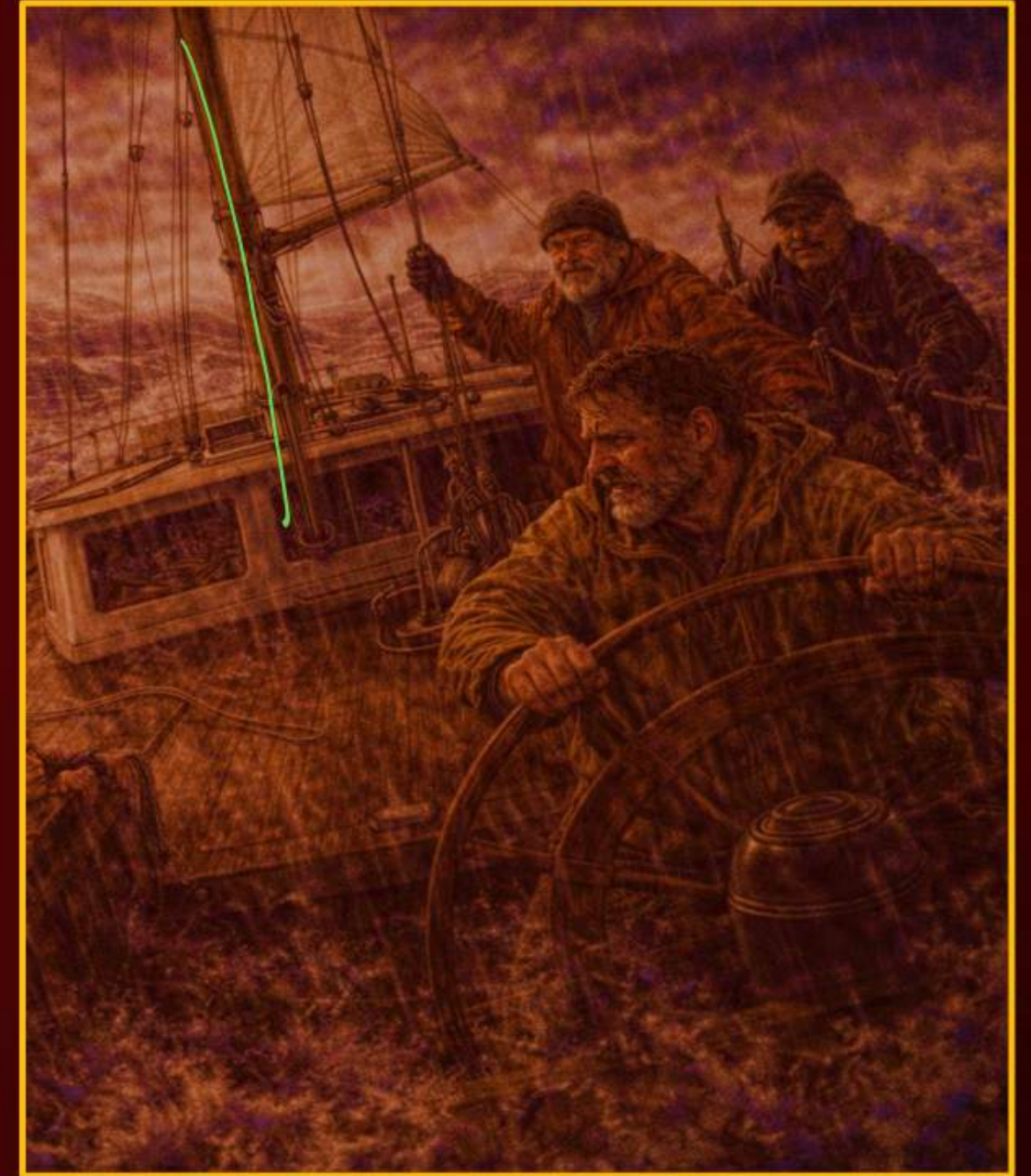


# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **The New Year Storm**

On January 2, 1977, their worst fears came true. For seven days they had been facing terrible weather, but now the sea turned into a wild monster. Waves rose twice as high as their ship, and the wind roared at 130 kilometres per hour. They were all exhausted after continuously battling the storm, but the situation was still getting worse.

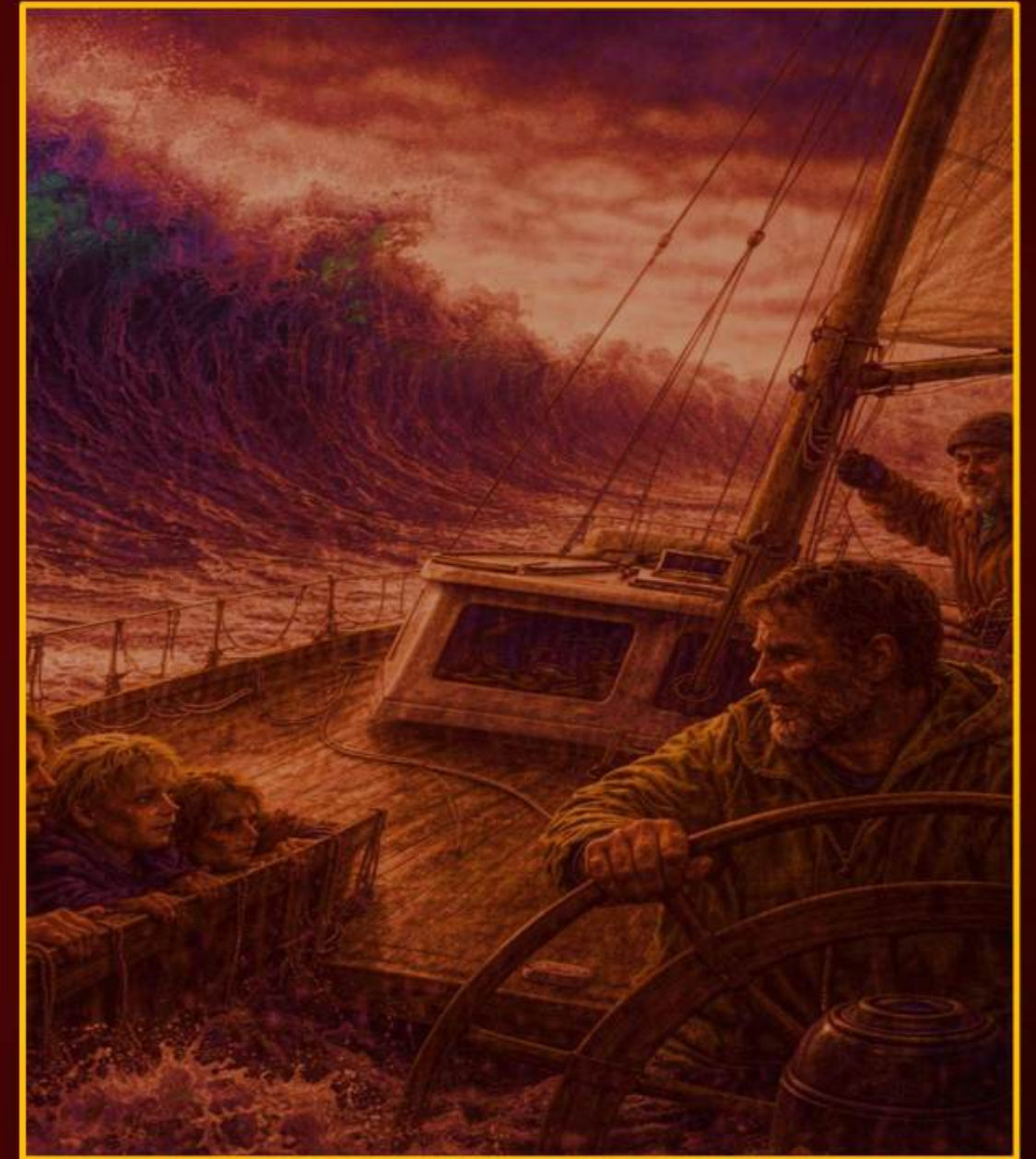


# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **The Giant Wave**

By the evening of January 2, it seemed that the storm was weakening. At six o'clock, the sea looked calmer. But an hour later, Gordon noticed something terrifying—a gigantic wave unlike anything he had ever seen before. It looked like a black mountain of water, towering over them and rushing towards the boat. Their Wavewalker seemed like a small toy in front of it.



# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **The Wave Strikes**

Gordon acted quickly. He slowed the boat, checked all ropes, and told everyone to wear life jackets and tie themselves with lifelines for safety. Then he returned to the wheel. Suddenly, the huge wave crashed down on them. The boat was lifted high into the air, then thrown violently down. Gordon was hurled across the deck, his ribs cracked, and his head was badly hurt. He was thrown overboard into the sea. For a moment, he thought it was the end. But another wave pushed him back towards the boat, and he managed to grab the rails and climb back on deck.

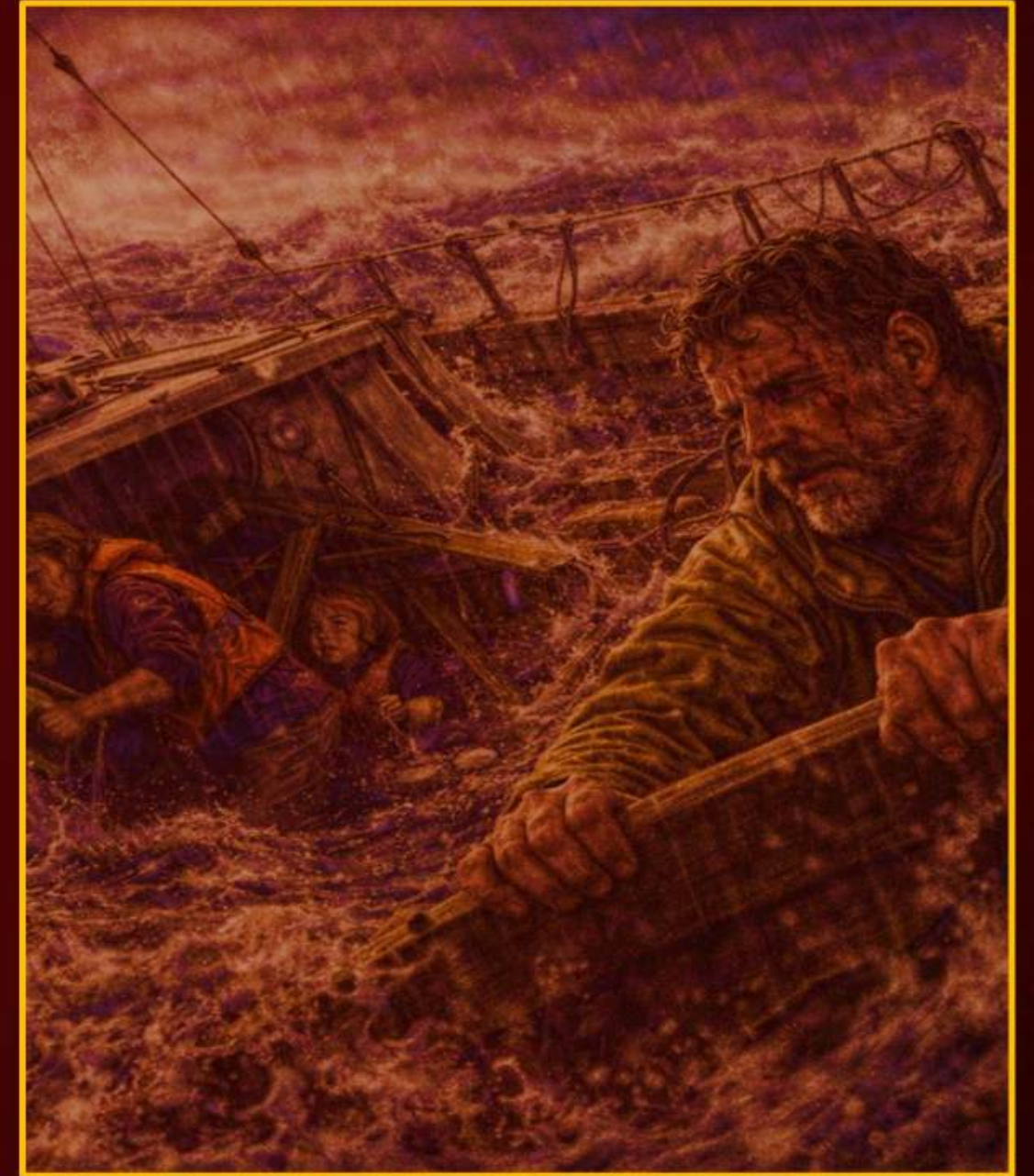


# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **Damage to Wavewalker**

The condition of Wavewalker was terrible. The main mast had broken, sails were torn, the side rails were smashed, and water was flooding inside. The steering wheel was useless. Inside the boat, woodwork and equipment were destroyed. Gordon himself was badly injured with a swollen head, broken ribs, and a bleeding mouth, but he ignored the pain. His only focus was on saving his family and the boat.



**“We’re Not Afraid to Die...  
if we Can All Be Together”**



### **Struggling Through the Night**

For the next fifteen hours, everyone worked tirelessly. Larry and Herb pumped water continuously, Mary helped them, and Gordon tried to make temporary repairs. The electric pump had failed because of short-circuiting, so they had to pump water by hand. Water kept rushing in, and it seemed almost impossible to save the boat. But no one gave up, and the fight continued all through the night of January 2 and into January 3.

# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **Children Show Courage**

During this desperate time, Gordon went to check on his children. Suzanne had been badly injured. She had a deep cut on her head, two black eyes, and a swollen face. Later she needed six stitches. Yet she did not complain. She whispered to her father, “I don’t want to worry you when you are trying to save us all.” Jonathan, only six years old, said something even more inspiring: “Daddy, we aren’t afraid to die... if we can all be together.” These brave words filled Gordon with strength and determination to go on.



**“We’re Not Afraid to Die...  
if we Can All Be Together”**



### **Temporary Repairs**

Using canvas, plastic sheets, and spare ropes, Gordon managed to cover the broken areas of the boat. This slowed the flooding and gradually reduced the water level inside. The storm continued for another thirty-six hours, but thanks to these repairs, the Wavewalker stayed afloat.

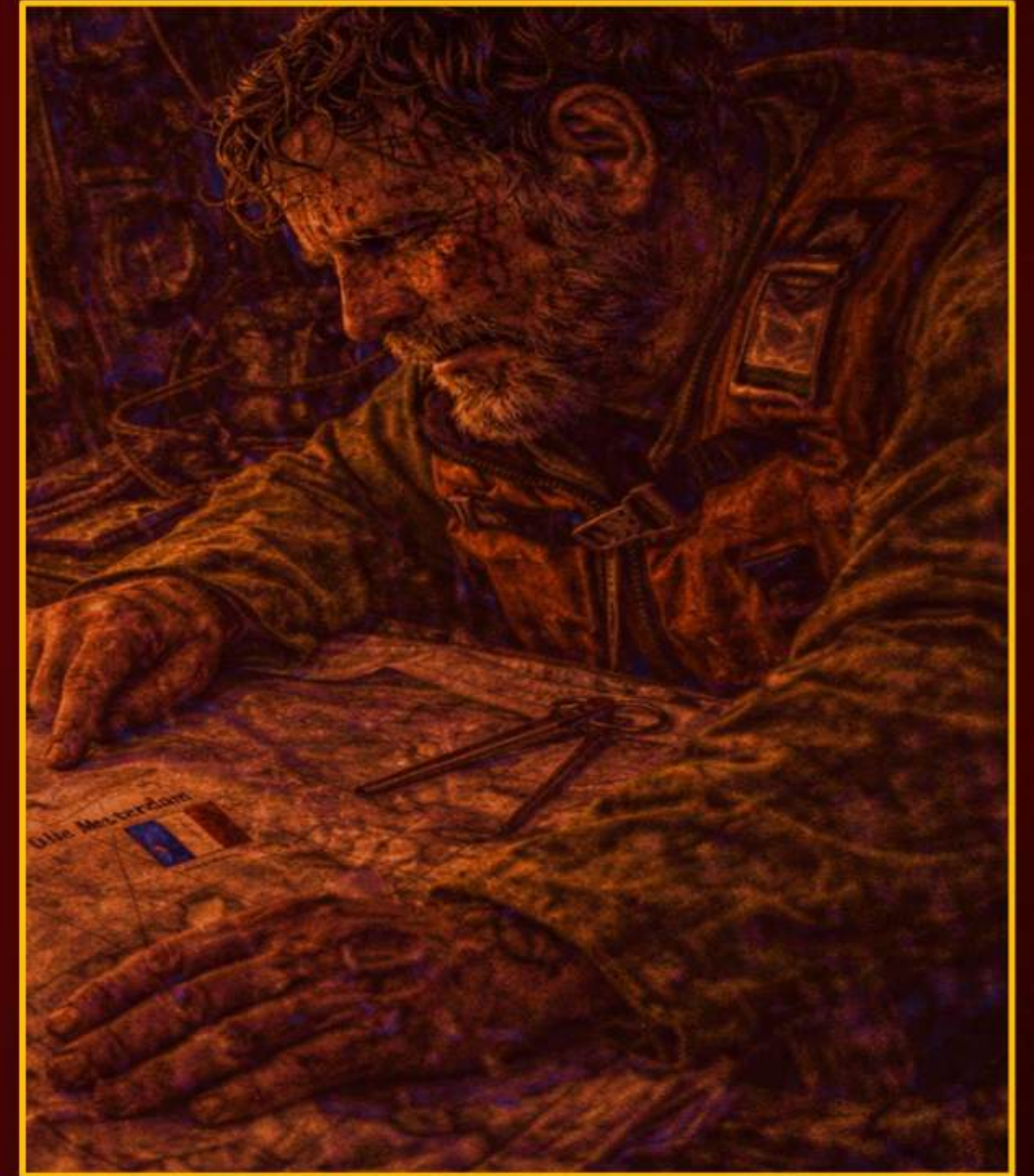


# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **Searching for Land**

Now Gordon had to think of where to go. Checking his charts, he realised that their only hope was to reach Amsterdam Island, a small volcanic island in the southern Indian Ocean belonging to the French. Another nearby island was Île de St. Paul, but Amsterdam was closer. It was about sixty-five kilometres away, but with their damaged boat, even this short distance was a great challenge.

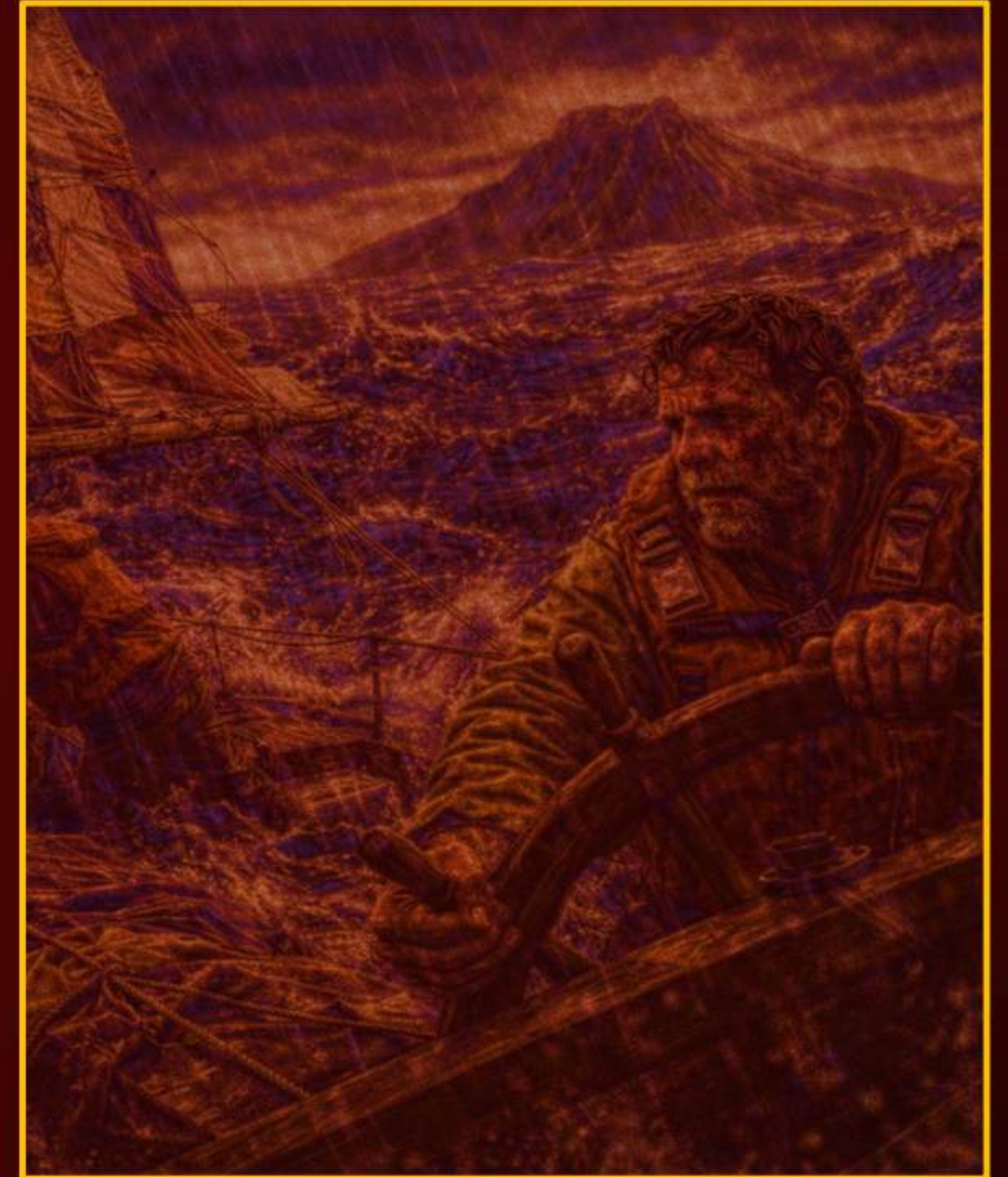


# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **Sailing Towards Amsterdam Island**

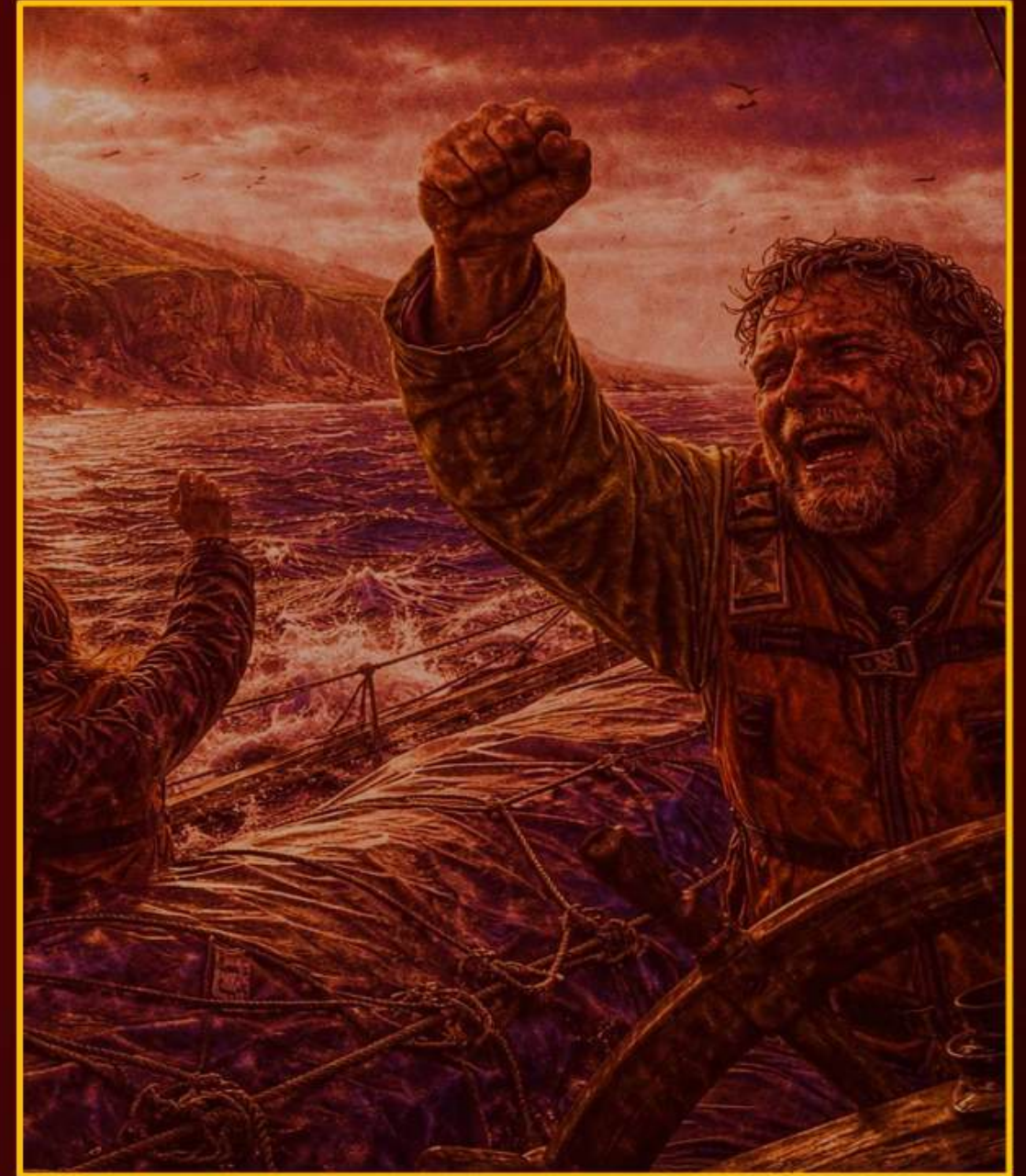
On January 4 and 5, the crew struggled towards Amsterdam Island. The compass was damaged, so navigation was uncertain. Still, Gordon managed rough calculations and steered as best as he could. The patched sails carried them slowly. The waves were still high and violent, and each one threatened to sink them. Everyone was weak, bruised, and hungry, but they held on with courage.



**“We’re Not Afraid to Die...  
if we Can All Be Together”**

### **Land at Last**

On January 6, 1977, they finally saw Amsterdam Island in the distance. The sight of land filled them with joy and relief. They cried tears of happiness. After endless struggle, they reached the shore safely.



# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**

## **Safe on Amsterdam Island**

Amsterdam Island had only twenty-eight inhabitants, mostly French scientists and workers. They welcomed the family warmly, gave them food, shelter, and medical care. Suzanne’s wounds were stitched properly, and the family could finally rest after their terrifying ordeal.



# **“We’re Not Afraid to Die... if we Can All Be Together”**



## **The Lesson of Courage**

This experience taught Gordon that courage, determination, and unity are the most powerful forces in life. His wife and crew had worked with great strength, but above all, it was his children's bravery that gave him the will to fight. Suzanne endured her pain silently, and Jonathan's words, "We aren't afraid to die if we can all be together," became the inspiration that carried them through the storm. The story shows that when people stand together with hope and courage, even the fiercest storms can be overcome.



## QUESTION



List the steps taken by the captain

- (i) to protect the ship when rough weather began.
- (ii) to check the flooding of the water in the ship.

## ANSWER:

- (i) To protect the ship when rough weather began, the captain planned to slow the ship down. The storm jib was dropped and the mooring rope which was heavy was lashed in a loop over the stem. Everything was double-fastened and they went through the life-raft drill.
- (ii) Herb and Larry started to pump the water out. The canvas was stretched by the captain and the waterproof hatch covers were secured across the gaping holes. When the electric pump short circuited and two hand pumps were blocked, he noticed another electric pump and started it by connecting it to an earth pipe.

## QUESTION



Describe the mental condition of the voyagers on 4th and 5th January.

## ANSWER:

On 4th January, after pumping out water continuously for 36 hours, the voyagers felt relieved. They consumed their first meal in two days. But their break was short-lived. On 5th January, they faced a dangerous situation. The fear of death appeared huge and they underwent great mental stress.

## QUESTION



Describe the shifts in the narration of the events as indicated in the three sections of the text. Give a subtitle to each section.

## ANSWER:

The first section explains a peaceful journey from Plymouth in England to 3500 km east of Cape Town in Africa. The narrator is fully confident and relaxed. Then they faced huge waves as the weather deteriorated. To save themselves, they took precautionary measures and struggled with the disaster. The narration becomes grim, but exudes confidence and illustrates their fighting spirit and strong will power. The Wave-walker rode out of the storm by 6th January morning, and by evening, they sighted the Ile Amsterdam Island. Now the narrator is relaxed. Relief, joy and confidence are apparent.

## QUESTION



What difference did you notice between the reaction of the adults and the children when faced with danger?

## ANSWER:

There are lots of differences in the way the children and adults reacted when faced with danger. The adults initially felt the stress of the situation. But they soon garnered strength and prepared themselves to face it. When the rough weather began, enough precautions were taken to protect the ship. Everyone was equipped with water-proof clothes, lifelines and life jackets. Herb and Larry worked optimistically and cheerfully for three continuous days to pump the water out from the ship. The narrator at the wheel was replaced by Mary who steered the ship when the deck was smashed. She served them meals after a struggle of two days against all odds. As a captain, the narrator performed his role with determination, courage, responsibility and resourcefulness.

He undertook the repair work by providing apparatus and giving the directions which were required to protect the ship. He helped in steering the ship towards the island. The children suffered patiently and silently. Sue, with her troubles, did not bother her father. Jon behaved courageously and was not scared to die if everyone perished together.

Resourcefulness. He undertook the repair work by providing apparatus and giving the directions which were required to protect the ship. He helped in steering the ship towards the island. The children suffered patiently and silently. Sue, with her troubles, did not bother her father. Jon behaved courageously and was not scared to die if everyone perished together.

## QUESTION



How does the story suggest that optimism helps to endure "the direst stress"?

## ANSWER:

The story suggests that optimism helps to endure "the direst stress". The behaviour of four adults throughout the crisis bears it out. Herb Seigler and Larry Vigil were the two crewmen. As the deck was smashed by the huge waves, water entered the ship from the openings and holes. From the evening of 2nd January, Herb and Larry started to pump out water. They worked feverishly, excitedly and continuously for about 36 hours. As a result of pumping continuously, they reached the last few centimeters of water on 4th January. They stayed optimistic and cheerful while facing dangerous situations. The narrator did not lose his presence of mind, hope or courage while facing problems. He was not worried about the equipment loss and used whatever was present there. His practical knowledge and self-confidence helped them steer out of the storm and reach the Ile Amsterdam Island. In those difficult hours, Mary remained at the wheel. She did not lose courage or hope either.

## QUESTION



What lessons do we learn from such hazardous experiences when we are face-to-face with death?

## ANSWER:

Hazardous experiences bring us face-to-face with death and impart a few crucial lessons. Our life is not always a bed of roses. We must respond to risks and danger with fortitude and patience. The real test of character is adversity. The purity of gold is decided by putting it on fire. So, hazardous experiences of life bring the best out of us. Before death, cowards die many times. Negative feelings like fear lead to inactivity and abject surrender to situations. Such soldiers or sailors lose the war against difficulties in life. On the other hand, people with courage, self-confidence, presence of mind and resourcefulness face the dangers bravely and successfully come out of all disasters. Their caring and sharing attitude inspires others to face difficult situations boldly and steer through them with fortitude.

## QUESTION



Why do you think people undertake such adventurous expeditions in spite of the risks involved?

## ANSWER:

Human beings are adventurous by nature. The higher the risk, the more the thrill. The thrill of exploring lands and discovering the beauty and wealth which lies hidden in far-off lands inspires brave people to even put their lives at stake. Maybe, they value one hour of glory more than an uneventful long life of inactivity and sloth. At times, adventures are risky and prove deadly. The failure of a few people does not discourage true lovers of adventure. They learn lessons from errors and shortcomings of others and make new attempts with greater zeal. The key to an adventurous expedition lies in adapting to the situations and overcoming the problems. The victory of an adventurous expedition brings wealth, fame and glory. History books are full with accounts of well-known explorers such as Vasco da Gama, Columbus, Captain Scott and Captain Cook.

## QUESTION



We have come across words like 'gale' and 'storm' in the account. Here are two more words for 'storm': typhoon, cyclone. How many words does your language have for 'storm'?

## ANSWER:

The Hindi language has the following words for 'storm': toofan, aandhi, chakravat, and jhanjavat

## QUESTION



Here are the terms for different kinds of vessels: yacht, boat, canoe, ship, steamer, schooner. Think of similar terms in your language.

## ANSWER:

Similar terms in Hindi for vessels which are used to travel on water are nava, nauka, jahaj, and pot

## QUESTION



'Catamaran' is a kind of a boat. Do you know which Indian language this word is derived from? Check the dictionary.

## ANSWER:

'Catamaran' is a word derived from Tamil which means 'tied wood'. It is a boat or yacht containing twin hulls in parallel. It is defined as 'a fast sailing boat with two hulls' in the dictionary.

## QUESTION



Have you heard any boatmen's songs? What kind of emotions do these songs usually express?

## ANSWER:

The boatmen's songs invite other sailors to awaken, arise and come to the sea to explore its wealth. These are inspirational songs that provide moral support to the hard-working boatmen.

**PROSE – 3**  
**DISCOVERING TUT: THE SAGA**  
**CONTINUES**

# Discovering Tut



3300 years ago

## Tut's death and mystery

Tutankhamun, the last heir of a powerful royal family of Egypt's New Kingdom, died when he was still a teenager. His death was sudden and has always been a mystery. He was buried with unimaginable riches – gold and treasures – which showed how much importance Egyptians gave to the afterlife. His tomb was discovered in 1922 by Howard Carter, and ever since, the young king's life and death have fascinated people. Many suspected he might have been murdered. Now, after more than 80 years, scientists prepared to investigate him with the help of modern technology – a CT scanner – that could provide a complete picture of his body and maybe recreate what he looked like.

# Discovering Tut



## The scene at Tut's tomb in 2005

It was 6 p.m. on 5 January 2005, at the Valley of the Kings. The evening was stormy – wind was strong, dust was rising, and dark clouds spread across the desert. Inside the tomb, Tut's body was taken out from the resting place and moved towards the CT machine. This machine was like a giant camera that could take hundreds of X-ray slices of his body. Earlier that day, many tourists had come to see the tomb, admired the paintings on the walls, and gazed at Tut's face on his golden coffin. The author points out the contrast – in the day the tomb was a tourist spot, and in the evening it turned into a scientific laboratory. Tut was about to be examined in a way no one from his time could have imagined.

# Discovering Tut



## **Carter's discovery and what happened to Tut's body**

The head of the Egyptian Supreme Council of Antiquities, Dr. Zahi Hawass, said Tut's mummy was in "bad condition because of what Carter did in the 1920s." Howard Carter, the British archaeologist, found Tut's tomb in 1922. Though the tomb had been robbed long ago, many objects were still there – golden collars, necklaces, amulets, rings, daggers, cups, and the most famous gold mask. These were meant to protect the king in the afterlife. There were also ordinary things – food, wine, games, clothes – to make him comfortable after death. But Carter faced a problem: the body had been cemented to the bottom of the coffin with hardened resins. Gentle methods failed. Even heating the coffin in the sun for hours did not work. Finally, Carter's men cut the mummy into pieces. They separated the head and all major joints. They then reassembled the body and placed it into a wooden box. Carter did it because he feared thieves might damage the body if he left it. But this rough treatment left the mummy badly damaged forever.

## Modern archaeology and CT scanning

The author explains that archaeology has changed since Carter's time. Today archaeologists are not interested only in treasure but in knowledge – even small remains like seeds, hair, or pottery can give clues about history. In 1968, a medical X-ray showed that Tut's chest bones and sternum (breastbone) were missing. That raised new questions. Now with CT (computed tomography), a better technique was available. A CT scan takes many slices of X-ray images and combines them into a 3D picture, just like slices of bread make a loaf. With CT, scientists hoped to find out how Tut died, whether he was murdered or died naturally, and also his exact age at death.

# Discovering Tut



## Tut's dynasty and the Amarna period

The story now shifts to Tut's place in history. Tutankhamun was a descendant of a royal family that had ruled Egypt for centuries. His grandfather Amenhotep III ruled for almost 40 years. After him came Amenhotep IV, who shocked people by changing his name to Akhenaten. He promoted the worship of Aten, the sun god, and closed temples of the old god Amun. He even destroyed their images. He moved the capital from Thebes to a new city he built, Amarna. This religious revolution disturbed the people. Akhenaten's family was mysterious and troubled. After his death, a short-lived ruler Smenkhkare appeared, and then Tut, a child, came to the throne. Tut changed his name from Tutankhaten to Tutankhamun, showing he returned to the old religion of Amun. He ruled for nine years before dying suddenly. His death ended the dynasty and left behind many mysteries.

# Discovering Tut



## The Egyptian Mummy Project and the scan

In 2003, the Egyptian Mummy Project was started to study and record details of all ancient mummies. Tut was one of the first to be examined. A portable CT machine, donated by Siemens and the National Geographic Society, was brought to the Valley of the Kings. On 5 January 2005, Tut's body was scanned. It produced around 1700 images. The head was scanned in 0.62 mm slices, giving very clear details. But there was a small problem: sand had entered the cooler fan of the machine, and it stopped working for some time. People became nervous, and a guard jokingly said it was the "curse of the pharaoh." However, the team fixed the problem and finished the scan successfully. In less than three hours, Tut's body was put back in his tomb. The images showed his bones clearly, and scientists could rotate the head in any direction on a computer screen. Hawass looked relieved and proud that modern science had given new life to the study of the boy king.

## Conclusion

The chapter ends with a sense of respect. Tut, the teenage king, died more than 3,300 years ago, but modern science is still chasing answers about his life and death. His story links the past and the present. Archaeology has moved from treasure hunting to careful study, and CT scanning may finally solve mysteries that even time could not erase.

## QUESTION



King Tut's body has been subjected to repeated scrutiny.

## ANSWER:

King Tut's body has been repeatedly examined because he died at a very young age under mysterious circumstances. Scholars and scientists have been curious to find the cause of his untimely death and gather more information about his life and reign.

## QUESTION



Howard Carter's investigation was resented.

## ANSWER:

Howard Carter's investigation was resented because he damaged the mummy during his examination. In his attempt to remove Tut's body from the coffin, he cut it into several pieces. This act was considered unscientific and disrespectful by many historians and scholars.

## QUESTION



Carter had to chisel away the solidified resins to raise the king's remains.

## ANSWER:

Carter had to chisel away the hardened resins because the body had become firmly glued to the coffin due to the application of large amounts of resin during burial. The sun's heat failed to loosen it, so Carter used a chisel and hammer to remove the remains.

## QUESTION



Tut's body was buried along with gilded treasures.

## ANSWER:

Tut's body was buried with gilded treasures because the ancient Egyptians believed in life after death. They thought that the king would need these items in the afterlife for comfort, protection, and royal status.

## QUESTION



Explain the statement: "King Tut is one of the first mummies to be scanned in death, as in life..."

## ANSWER:

The statement means that King Tut, who was an important figure in life, continued to attract attention even in death. He was among the first mummies to undergo a modern CT scan, symbolizing how he remained significant in both life and after death through scientific and historical study.

## QUESTION



The boy king changed his name from Tutankhaten to Tutankhamun.

## ANSWER:

Tutankhaten changed his name to Tutankhamun to show his devotion to the god Amun and to distance himself from his father Akhenaten's unpopular monotheistic worship of Aten. This marked a return to traditional religious practices.

## QUESTION



What were the results of the CT scan?

## ANSWER:

The CT scan of King Tut's body provided detailed internal images. It showed that his head and bones were in good condition. No evidence of a fatal blow to the head or major bone injuries was found. Although the exact cause of death remained unclear, the scan helped rule out some theories and allowed further scientific investigation.

**PROSE – 4**  
**The Ailing Planet:**  
**The Green Movement's Role**

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Beginning of the Green Movement**

The essay opens by saying that a revolutionary change came in 1972. It was in that year that the Green Movement began and gave a new direction to human thinking all over the world. Before this, people thought that the Earth and its resources could be used without limit. But in 1972, people began to realize that the Earth's resources were not infinite and must be protected.

This movement started the idea that man and nature are not enemies but partners in survival. It awakened the human race to the danger of destroying its own home — the planet Earth.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **A Change in Human Attitude**

Palkhivala says that a great change has come in the way people think. For a long time, human beings believed they were masters of nature, who could rule, exploit, and control it. But now people have understood that they are not the owners of this planet; they are only a part of it. If we destroy nature, we destroy ourselves.

This change in attitude — from dominance to coexistence — is described as the “Green Revolution of the human spirit.” It is more important than any scientific or industrial revolution because it changes how we think about life itself.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Earth as a Living Organism**

Now, scientists see the Earth as a living organism. It has its own systems that help it survive. But because of human greed and misuse of resources, the Earth is now ailing—that is, sick.

Palkhivala calls our planet “The Ailing Planet” because it is suffering due to the damage caused by humans. The environment, forests, animals, and rivers are all crying for help. The Green Movement tries to heal the planet before it becomes too late.

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## **The United Nations Report**

The author then refers to a report of the United Nations. This report was a warning to mankind. It said that the condition of the Earth is very poor and that the planet's ability to support life is being destroyed. The report clearly mentions that the human population has grown too much and that the demands on Earth are much more than it can supply.

The report made it clear that the Earth is not just a storehouse of resources—it is a living system that must be cared for and respected.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Concept of Sustainable Development**

Palkhivala then explains that the future of humanity depends on sustainable development. He defines it as development that meets the needs of the present without harming the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.

This means we must not use all our resources now and leave nothing for our children and grandchildren. We should live within our means and respect the limits of nature.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Four Biological Systems**

**The author says that all life on Earth depends on four main biological systems:**

1. Fisheries (marine life)
2. Forests (trees and plants)
3. Grasslands (for grazing animals)
4. Croplands (for growing food)

These four systems are the foundation of our survival, as they provide us with food, raw materials, and other essential things. But human activity has put all these systems under great stress. If they collapse, life on Earth will be impossible.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **Overfishing**

Palkhivala explains that the first biological system, fisheries, is being overused. People are catching fish faster than fish can reproduce. As a result, the population of fish is decreasing at an alarming rate.

He mentions that many fishing industries now catch young fish before they have grown and reproduced. This practice threatens to destroy the entire marine ecosystem.

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## **Deforestation**

The second biological system, forests, is in even greater danger. Trees are being cut down everywhere to provide fuel, timber, and land for cultivation.

When forests disappear, rainfall becomes irregular, soil is eroded, and the air becomes polluted. Forests are called the “lungs of the Earth” because they produce oxygen and absorb carbon dioxide. But by cutting down forests, we are making the planet suffocate.

The author mentions that in many developing countries, including India, poor villagers cut trees for firewood because they have no other source of energy. This causes serious damage to the environment.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role** *Nani Palkhivala*

## **Overgrazing and Loss of Grasslands**

The third biological system, grasslands, is also in danger. These areas are meant to feed cattle and other animals. But because the number of animals has increased, the grass is being eaten faster than it can grow again.

Overgrazing makes fertile land turn into desert. When this happens, animals have nothing left to eat, and people lose their means of livelihood.

Thus, human greed and population pressure have destroyed the balance of nature.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **Damage to Croplands**

The fourth system, croplands, is where we grow our food. But these lands are becoming less fertile because of overuse. Farmers use chemical fertilizers and pesticides to increase crop production.

At first, this seems helpful, but slowly, these chemicals destroy the fertility of the soil. They also pollute rivers and underground water.

In short, by trying to grow more food to feed our growing population, we are poisoning our land and water.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role** *Nani Palkhivala*

## **The Earth's Carrying Capacity**

Palkhivala explains that the Earth has a limited carrying capacity. It can only support a certain number of people and animals. But the human population is growing so fast that the planet cannot bear the pressure.

He warns that if population growth is not controlled, the Earth will not be able to provide food, water, and shelter for everyone.

He uses the example of India, where the population increases by about 15.5 million every year — equal to the entire population of Australia. This puts a terrible strain on all resources.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Population Explosion**

The author calls this uncontrolled growth a Population Explosion . He says that developing countries like India and China suffer the most from it.

More people mean more demand for food, housing, water, and energy — and this demand leads to more pollution, deforestation, and exploitation of nature.

He points out that population control is not only necessary for economic progress but also for environmental survival.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Question of Development**

Some people think that development means having more factories, roads, and machines. But Palkhivala argues that real development is something else.

True development means growth with balance — it means using resources in a way that benefits both the present and future generations.

He emphasizes that we must have sustainable development, not blind industrial growth that destroys forests, pollutes the air, and kills rivers.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Role of the Government**

The author praises India for being the first country in the world to make environmental protection a part of its Constitution.

According to Article 48A, the State must protect and improve the environment and safeguard forests and wildlife.

However, he also says that although we have good laws, they are often not followed. Many people, companies, and even government agencies ignore them.

He stresses that laws alone cannot help unless people also change their attitude.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Idea of Trusteeship**

Palkhivala then says that we are only trustees of this planet, not its owners.

This idea was inspired by Mahatma Gandhi, who believed that the world has enough for everyone's need but not for everyone's greed.

As trustees, it is our duty to take care of the Earth and pass it on to the next generation in a healthy condition.

If we continue to misuse it, we are stealing the future of our children.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **The Responsibility of Each Individual**

The author explains that protecting the planet is not just the duty of the government — every person must play their part.

He says that people must be educated about the environment. They must realize that small changes, like planting trees, saving water, or avoiding plastic, can make a big difference.

If every individual acts responsibly, the Earth can recover and heal.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role *Nani Palkhivala***

## **Hope for the Future**

Finally, Nani Palkhivala ends his essay with a message of hope.

He believes that although the situation is serious, it is not hopeless. If human beings realize their mistakes and change their behavior, the planet can still be saved.

He urges all nations — rich and poor — to come together and work for the common good of the Earth.

He dreams of a future where human beings live in harmony with nature, respecting all forms of life.

# **The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role** *Nani Palkhivala*

## **Conclusion**

Nani Palkhivala's "The Ailing Planet: The Green Movement's Role" is a strong warning to mankind.

It reminds us that the Earth is a living organism that is becoming sick.

Human greed and overpopulation are destroying forests, rivers, and wildlife.

The four biological systems — fisheries, forests, grasslands, and croplands — are in great danger.

Development must be sustainable.

We are trustees of this planet, not its owners.

The essay calls for a change in human attitude — from exploitation to protection — so that future generations can inherit a healthy, green, and living planet.

## QUESTION



Locate the lines in the text that support the title 'The Ailing Planet'

## ANSWER:

The lines that support the title are: "The Earth's vital signs reveal a patient in declining health." "It is a grim reminder of the changing perception — from mechanistic to holistic view of the world." These lines show that the planet is suffering due to human exploitation, much like a sick patient who needs urgent care

## QUESTION



What does the notice 'The world's most dangerous animal' at a cage in the zoo at Lusaka, Zambia, signify?

## ANSWER:

The notice refers to humans as the most dangerous animal. The cage has only a mirror inside it. This is a symbolic way to show that human beings are responsible for the destruction of the environment, and unless they change, they will continue harming the planet.

## QUESTION



How are the Earth's principal biological systems being depleted?

## ANSWER:

The Earth's four biological systems — fisheries, forests, grasslands, and croplands — are being depleted due to overuse and misuse. Overfishing, deforestation, overgrazing, and excessive farming are exhausting these systems and reducing their capacity to regenerate.

## QUESTION



Why is tropical forest called the powerhouse of evolution?

## ANSWER:

Tropical forests are called the powerhouse of evolution because they are home to a vast variety of plants and animals. These forests support biodiversity and are a crucial part of the Earth's ecological system, promoting life and evolutionary processes.

## QUESTION



Why does the author aver that growth of the world population is one of the strongest factors distorting the future of human society?

## ANSWER:

The author stresses that without population control, all efforts to protect the environment and ensure sustainable development will fail. Thus, it is crucial to address population growth to secure a better and balanced future for humanity.

A red, 3D-style banner with a yellow and orange gradient border, containing the text 'PROSE – 5' and 'THE ADVENTURE'.

**PROSE – 5**  
**THE ADVENTURE**

# The Adventure *Jayant Narlikar*



## INTRODUCTION

“The Adventure” is a science fiction by Jayant V. Narlikar, an Indian astrophysicist and writer known for blending scientific ideas with storytelling. This story mixes history, science, and imagination. It revolves around Professor Gaitonde, a historian, who experiences something extraordinary — he suddenly finds himself in a world where Indian history is completely different from the one he knows. In that world, the Marathas defeated Ahmad Shah Abdali in the Battle of Panipat (1761), and because of that victory, India was never colonized by the British. When Gaitonde returns to his normal world, his friend Rajendra Deshpande, a physicist, gives a scientific explanation for his strange experience.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



The story starts with Gangadharpant Gaitonde – a history professor exploring a different world, searching for answers to some questions that had altered his understanding of the past and present. He was travelling to Bombay on the Jijamata Express. He had made a plan – researching by studying some books at a library and returning to Pune to talk to Rajendra Deshpande about his findings. He knew Rajendra Deshpande would help him solve his queries. However, Professor Gaitonde was also uncertain about the existence of his friend Rajendra Deshpande in this world.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



As Professor Gangadharpant Gaitonde came out of the Bombay station, he was shocked to see the grand building of The East India Company still active and flourishing, with officials moving in and out as if it were the centre of power. He could hardly believe it, because according to all historical records, the East India Company had been dissolved after 1857, following the great revolt when the British Crown took direct control of India. He reasoned that perhaps he had somehow arrived in a time before 1857, when the Company still ruled the country, and decided to find out more. Hoping to see something familiar, he went to the Forbes building to meet his son, Vinay Gaitonde, who worked there. But when he asked the English receptionist about his son, she looked through the records and replied politely that there was no employee named Vinay Gaitonde in the office. The professor was stunned. A sudden, frightening thought crossed his mind — if he himself was dead or had never existed in this strange world, then his son could not be alive either. Perhaps his son was never born at all. This realization left him deeply disturbed and confused, as everything around him seemed unreal and unfamiliar.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



As Professor Gaitonde continued to explore the strange version of Bombay, he came across the Town Hall, which housed a large library. Curious to learn more about this unfamiliar world, he went inside and asked the librarian to give him a list of history books, including those written by him. When the list was brought, he was relieved to see his own name among the authors, which meant that in this world too, he existed as a historian. He began to go through the books eagerly, searching for the point where history had taken a different turn. As he read one of the volumes, he was shocked to find that, contrary to all known history, the book described the Battle of Panipat as ending in a Maratha victory over Ahmad Shah Abdali. According to this version, Vishwasrao survived, the Marathas reorganized their forces, and their victory established their supremacy in Northern India. The writing style of the book was clearly his own — the same expressions and tone — but the content was entirely unfamiliar to him. He read on with amazement as the book explained that, after this great triumph, the East India Company had chosen to stop its expansionist plans in India, realizing that it could not challenge the powerful and united Maratha Empire.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



In the strange new world, Professor Gaitonde discovered that the history books written under his name contained astonishing information. One of his books described Vishwasrao, the new Maratha ruler, and his brother Madhavrao as brave and intelligent leaders who had used their political wisdom and courage to expand Maratha power all over India. Under their leadership, India had made remarkable progress, especially in the fields of science and technology, with assistance from the East India Company, which now worked in friendly cooperation with the Indian rulers instead of trying to dominate them. As he read further, Professor Gaitonde was amazed to learn that by the twentieth century, India had developed into a democratic nation, with a central parliament making the main decisions for the country. The Shahenshah (Emperor) of Delhi still existed, but his position had been reduced to that of a figurehead, whose role was merely to approve or “rubber-stamp” the decisions made by the elected parliament.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



Out of curiosity, Professor Gaitonde then picked up another book titled “Bhausahebanchi Bakhar”, which narrated the Battle of Panipat in vivid detail. The book described how, during the fierce fighting, a bullet had narrowly missed Vishwasrao, and this single event had changed the course of Indian history. Instead of dying on the battlefield, Vishwasrao survived, rallied his troops, and led the Marathas to victory — completely reversing the history that Professor Gaitonde knew. As he was making notes, the librarian approached him and politely reminded him that the library was about to close for the day. Lost in thought, Professor Gaitonde hurriedly gathered his papers. Without realizing it, he slipped the book “Bhausahebanchi Bakhar” into his left pocket, while keeping his notes in the right one, completely unaware that this absent-minded action would later become very important.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



After leaving the library, Professor Gaitonde found a small guest house where he decided to spend the night. He was still deeply puzzled by everything he had seen and read that day. After having a simple, frugal meal, he felt restless and thought that a short walk might help clear his mind. He wandered through the streets of Bombay until he reached the Azad Maidan, where a large pandal (tent) had been set up for a public meeting. A crowd had gathered, and a few people were sitting on the stage, apparently waiting for the event to begin. Gaitonde's eyes fell on the presidential chair placed at the centre of the stage — it was empty.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



Being a man of discipline and accustomed to public meetings, Professor Gaitonde believed that no meeting could begin without a presiding chairman. Thinking that he was doing the right thing, he confidently walked up to the stage and sat on the presidential chair. The crowd immediately became restless and started murmuring in protest. People shouted for him to get down, but Gaitonde tried to reason with them. He began to explain the importance of having a speaker on the presidential chair to guide the discussion and maintain order. However, the crowd did not listen to him. They grew angry and impatient, believing that he was interrupting their meeting without permission. Very soon, the situation got out of control — some people rushed towards the stage, pulled him out of the chair, and forcibly removed him from the platform. Professor Gaitonde was pushed and thrown off the stage by the furious audience, and before he could understand anything, he found himself falling — and then everything went black.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



The next scene takes place after the strange incident at Azad Maidan, where Professor Gangadharpant Gaitonde is now sitting and talking to his close friend, Professor Rajendra Deshpande, a scientist and physicist. Rajendra, who had been looking after him since the accident, gently asked what exactly Gaitonde had been doing before he was hit by the truck and lost consciousness. Gaitonde replied that, at that time, he had been deeply lost in thought about the Catastrophe Theory and how it might explain certain changes or sudden twists in historical events. Rajendra smiled slightly, thinking that Gaitonde's imagination had gone too far, but the historian quickly assured him that it wasn't just a trick of his mind or a dream.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



To prove that what he had experienced was real, Gaitonde reached into his pocket and pulled out a torn page from a book. He explained that it was from “Bhaushebanchi Bakhar”, the same book he had found and accidentally slipped into his left pocket while at the library in that strange version of Bombay. The page contained an account of the Battle of Panipat, describing how a bullet had narrowly missed Vishwasrao, and how this was seen by the Maratha soldiers as a good omen that gave them courage and ultimately led them to victory. Gaitonde then took out his own copy of the same book from his study — the one that existed in his normal world — and showed Rajendra that in this version, Vishwasrao was hit by the bullet and killed. The two compared the texts carefully, and the difference between the two versions of history left Rajendra completely astonished, unable to dismiss Gaitonde’s incredible experience as mere imagination.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



Rajendra went into a deep state of thought after listening carefully to Professor Gaitonde's strange experience. He sat silently for a while, trying to make sense of what he had just heard. Finally, he told Gaitonde that he would try to explain this extraordinary, almost catastrophic experience using two scientific theories. He pointed out that the torn page from Bhausahebanchi Bakhar, which described Vishwasrao's survival and victory, represented a crucial event turning in the opposite direction from the history they knew. This single difference, Rajendra explained, could have completely altered the course of history.

## The Adventure *Jayant Narlikar*



He then began to connect Gaitonde's experience with scientific reasoning. He said that reality is not limited to what we can see, hear, or feel through our senses — it might have other forms or manifestations beyond our normal perception. Even in the world of physics, he explained, it is not easy to predict the behavior of systems made up of atoms and their smaller particles, even if we know all the physical laws governing them. According to quantum theory, the behavior of such particles is uncertain and can exist in multiple possible states at the same time. For example, in different “world pictures” or alternative realities, an electron might exist in different positions. When we actually observe it and find its position, we are identifying which world or reality we are currently in. But, he added thoughtfully, the other possible worlds — where the electron is found in other positions — also continue to exist simultaneously.

In the same way, Rajendra suggested, there might be parallel worlds of history, where events have unfolded differently — one where Vishwasrao was hit and killed, leading to Maratha defeat, and another where the bullet missed, leading to their victory. Professor Gaitonde, somehow, might have slipped into that alternate world for a brief time and then returned to his own.

## The Adventure *Jayant Narlikar*



Rajendra continued his scientific explanation by saying that transitions occur in systems involving electrons and their subatomic particles. He explained that when an electron jumps from a higher energy level to a lower one, it emits radiation in the process. This kind of transition, he suggested thoughtfully, might also be possible at a macroscopic level — that is, in the large-scale world of human experiences. Listening intently, the astonished Gangadharpant Gaitonde asked whether it was actually possible that he had moved from one world to another and then come back to his original one.

Rajendra replied that in catastrophic situations, such as a major battle or historical turning point, there can exist radically different alternatives for the world's progress. However, the observer can only experience one reality at a time. He speculated that Gaitonde must have somehow made a transition to another possible world — one where the Marathas had won the Battle of Panipat — and had stayed there for two days before returning to the reality he originally belonged to. This meant that Gaitonde had experienced two worlds: one where the Marathas lost (his known reality) and another where they won (the alternate reality).

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



Rajendra concluded that in both worlds, the bifurcation or division of history had occurred at the Battle of Panipat, which served as the crucial point where history could have taken two entirely different paths. He emphasized that Gaitonde had not travelled to the past or the future, but rather existed in the present, experiencing a parallel world that had developed differently after that historical event. Rajendra also added that there could be many more such worlds, each formed by similar bifurcations at certain key points in the timeline, where history might have unfolded in countless other ways.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



Professor Gaitonde was deeply curious to understand why he had gone through such a strange and extraordinary experience. Rajendra tried to explain the possible scientific reason behind it. He said that for any kind of transition between two states or worlds, some interaction or trigger is always necessary. He suggested that perhaps Gaitonde's intense thinking about the catastrophe theory and its implications for wars and historical events might have been the key factor that caused the transition.

Rajendra reasoned that while Gaitonde was deeply absorbed in thoughts about the Battle of Panipat, the powerful concentration of his mind might have activated certain neurons in his brain, leading to an exceptional mental or physical transition to an alternative world — one in which history had taken a different course.

## **The Adventure** *Jayant Narlikar*



Listening to this, Gaitonde shared something that made the situation even more interesting. He told Rajendra that the topic for his thousandth presidential address — the lecture he was supposed to deliver before the accident — was actually going to be about “the consequences of the reverse outcome of the Battle of Panipat.” This meant that he had been mentally exploring the very idea of what would have happened if the Marathas had won instead of losing the battle. Thus, his intense focus and imagination on that particular event might have transported him temporarily into that alternate reality, making his experience both scientifically and psychologically fascinating.

## QUESTION



"Gangadharpant could not help comparing the country he knew with what he was witnessing around him."

## ANSWER:

This shows Professor Gaitonde's reaction when he finds himself in an alternate India that had not been colonized by the British. He mentally compares the real history he knows with the advanced and independent India he is witnessing. He is both amazed and confused by the stark differences.

## QUESTION



"The lack of determinism in quantum theory!"

## ANSWER:

This statement reflects a key idea from quantum physics that outcomes are not always predictable or fixed (unlike classical physics). Rajendra uses this to explain how multiple realities or histories could exist at the same time, and how Gaitonde might have experienced one such alternative possibility.

## QUESTION



"You need some interaction to cause a transition."

## ANSWER:

Rajendra says this to explain that to move from one state or reality to another, some physical or mental interaction is needed. In Professor Gaitonde's case, the collision with the truck might have been the trigger that caused his mind to transition into a parallel world.

## QUESTION



"You have obviously passed through the catastrophic experience – but you are back."

## ANSWER:

Rajendra acknowledges that Professor Gaitonde did experience a shift into another world, but he has now returned to his original reality. The word "catastrophic" again refers to the sudden shift in state as explained by the catastrophe theory.

# **PROSE – 6**

## **SILK ROAD**

## **Silk Road** *Nick Middleton*



The author of the chapter “Silk Road”, Nick Middleton, tells the story of his journey to Mount Kailash in Tibet. He wanted to do the holy walk called the kora, which means going around the sacred mountain. This journey was not just a travel experience for him but also a way to find peace and positivity. He believed that doing the kora would help him think more positively and bring that positive attitude into his everyday life.

## **Silk Road** *Nick Middleton*



When the author left a place called Ravu, he was joined by a man named Daniel, and their driver was Tsetan. A kind local woman named Lhamo gave the author a sheepskin coat as a gift to protect him from the cold. This coat was the usual dress of the drokbas, the nomadic herders of Tibet. Tsetan, who was an experienced driver, knew a route to Mount Kailash that went southwest and passed through several high mountain passes on the way.

## **Silk Road** *Nick Middleton*



As the author travelled further, he saw wide, dry grasslands where gazelles were eating the short grass. He also noticed dust clouds raised by kyang, the wild donkeys of Tibet. There were lonely drokbas (nomadic herders) taking care of their animals and tents of other nomads guarded by fierce Tibetan mastiffs. These huge and powerful dogs made the author understand why they were once used as hunting dogs in China's royal courts.

Soon, the group reached snow-covered mountains, which were very difficult to cross. The author noted that the altitude there was 5,210 metres above sea level. Because of the thin air and cold, his body functions slowed down, and he began to suffer from a severe headache.

## **Silk Road** *Nick Middleton*



They finally reached the top of the mountain pass, which was 5,515 metres above sea level and was marked by a pile of rocks. As they started going downhill, the author began to feel better and they stopped at a work camp near a dry salt lake. By the afternoon, they arrived at a small town called Hor. The author found Hor to be a sad and dull place with no greenery, only rocks and dust everywhere. Here, Daniel left the group and went back to Lhasa. The author felt disappointed because he had expected the Mansarovar Lake, on whose shore Hor was located, to be beautiful and peaceful, but instead, he found it dirty and full of garbage.

## **Silk Road** *Nick Middleton*



At last, they reached a guest house in Darchen late at night. The author was unable to sleep because he was not feeling well, so the next morning Tsetan took him to the Darchen medical college. After checking him, the doctors said that the author was fit and could do the kora. Once he was sure that the author was fine, Tsetan went back to Lhasa.

After getting a good night's rest, the author felt much better. Now, Darchen did not seem as bad as before. He described it as a dusty, broken-down town with only a few simple shops. The author noticed that there were very few pilgrims around and thought that he had come too early in the pilgrimage season. Because of the snow blocking the route, he decided not to do the kora alone.

## **Silk Road** *Nick Middleton*



While the author was waiting for the right time and weather to start the kora, he met a man named Norbu. Norbu was an academic researcher from the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences in Beijing, and he was studying the importance of the kora in Buddhist literature. As the author spent more time with him, he got to know Norbu better and learned that Norbu also wanted to do the kora. Since both of them were academicians and shared the same goal, they decided to do the pilgrimage together. The author felt happy and encouraged, thinking that his positive-thinking attitude was bringing good results once again.

### **CONCLUSION**

Throughout his journey, the author faced many difficulties and hardships, which at times made him feel negative and discouraged. However, he did not give up and continued with determination and hope. In the end, he met Norbu, someone who shared the same interest and purpose of completing the kora. Their shared motivation brought them together, and this lifted the author's spirits. The chapter ends on a positive and hopeful note, showing that positive thinking and perseverance can help overcome challenges and bring good results in life.

## **Themes of the Chapter**

1. **Adventure and Exploration** – The author's journey through the harsh Tibetan landscape.
2. **Faith and Spirituality** – Mount Kailash as a sacred place of worship.
3. **Human Connection** – Kindness and helpfulness of Tibetan people.
4. **Man vs Nature** – Facing challenges of weather, altitude, and terrain.
5. **Cultural Discovery** – Learning about Tibetan customs, traditions, and beliefs.

## QUESTION



The article has been titled 'Silk Road.'

## ANSWER:

The article is titled Silk Road because the author travelled through the mountains where the ancient Silk Road used to pass, connecting Tibet to China.

## QUESTION



Tibetan mastiffs were popular in China's imperial courts.

## ANSWER:

Tibetan mastiffs were ferocious and watchful guard dogs. When the author's vehicle entered the property, they chased it down without fear. As a result, they were presented to the Chinese imperial court as a form of tribute from Tibet.

## QUESTION



The author's experience at Hor was in stark contrast to earlier accounts of the place.

## ANSWER:

The author's experience at Hor contrasted with travel accounts such as those of Kawaguchi and Hedin, who were overcome by the beauty and serenity of the lake, and cried. The author observed a neglected Hor with sparse vegetation, a rocky and dusty landscape, and discarded waste in the surrounding area.

## QUESTION



The author thought that his positive thinking strategy worked well after all.

## ANSWER:

When the author discovered no pilgrims in Darchen, he began to doubt his positive thinking. But, by chance, he ran into Norbu, who had also come to do kora. He was a professor in Beijing. When he suggested that they both form a team, the author realised that his positive thinking had paid off after all.

## QUESTION



The purpose of the author's journey to Mount Kailash.

## ANSWER:

The author's trip to Mount Kailash was part of a self-improvement programme. The author wanted to boost his positive thinking, so he went on a pilgrimage called the kora.

## QUESTION



The author's physical condition in Darchen.

## ANSWER:

At Darchen, one of the author's nostrils became blocked. When he tried to sleep, he got up because his chest felt uneasy, though it was fine once he sat up. When he discovered he couldn't lie down, he tried sleeping by leaning against a wall, but he became afraid of falling asleep due to his breathing problem. He felt better after taking the medication.

## QUESTION



The author's meeting with Norbu.

## ANSWER:

Norbu and the author met by chance in Darchen's cafe. When Norbu noticed the author reading an English novel, he struck up a conversation, and they soon realised they were both headed for Korba. They decided to form a group.

## QUESTION



Tsetan's support to the author during the journey.

## ANSWER:

Tsetan drove the author from Ravu to Darchen in his four-wheel drive vehicle. He manoeuvred his way through the snowy terrain. When the author became ill, he also took him to the Darchen medical college. Throughout, Tsetan was a dependable and approachable companion.

## QUESTION



"As a Buddhist, he told me, he knew that it didn't really matter if I passed away, but he thought it would be bad for business."

## ANSWER:

Tsetan was a devout Buddhist who believed that death was not the end of the world. Kailash is a holy place; going there would be better for him because it would transport him to heaven. Then, if the author died there, it would be bad for his business because his credibility in looking after the tourists would be jeopardised, and he might not get any customers later.

# HOMework



Write down all the textual  
questions.

Prof  
H

**Thank**  
*You*